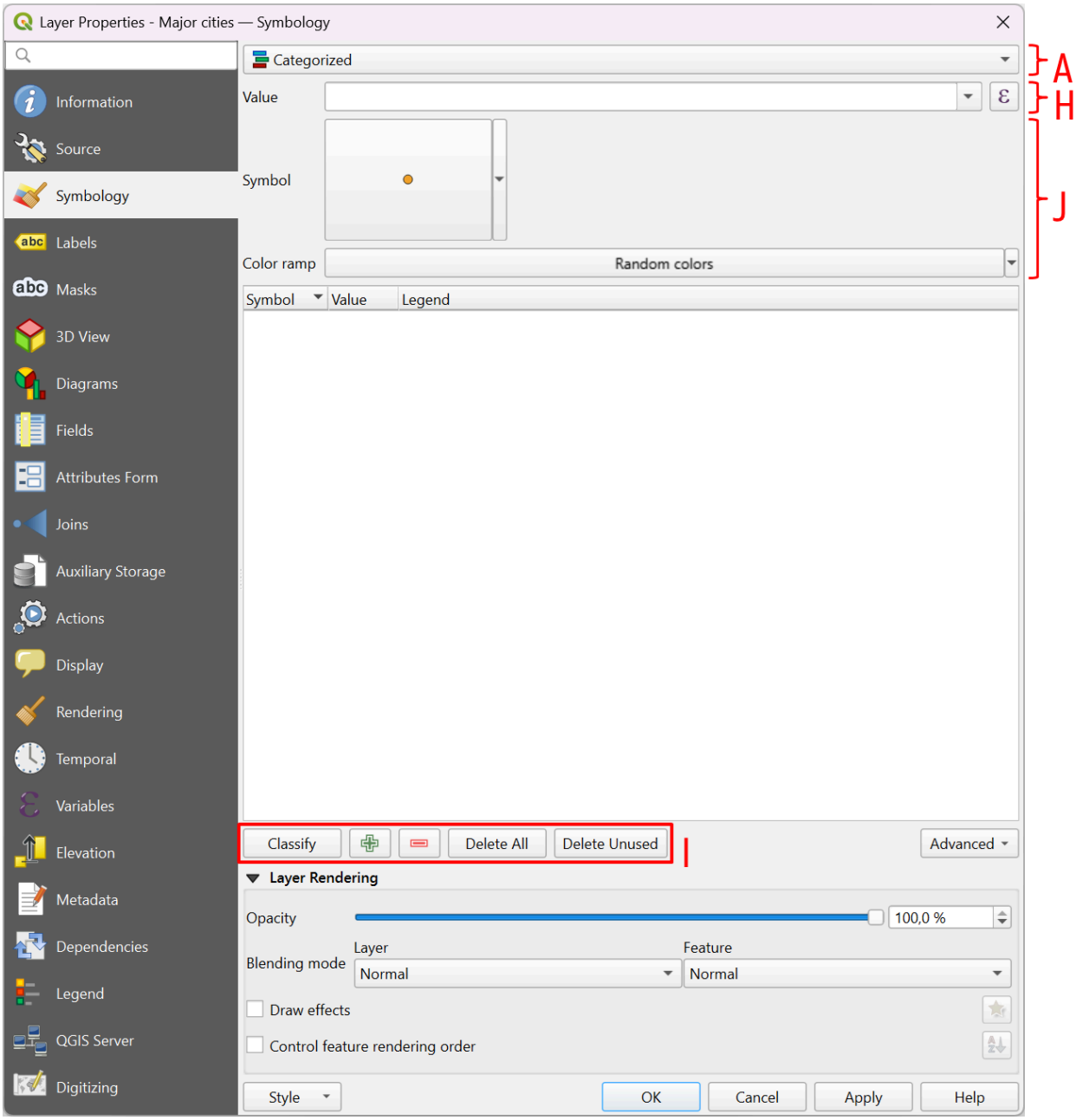
# 4.2.4 One style per category

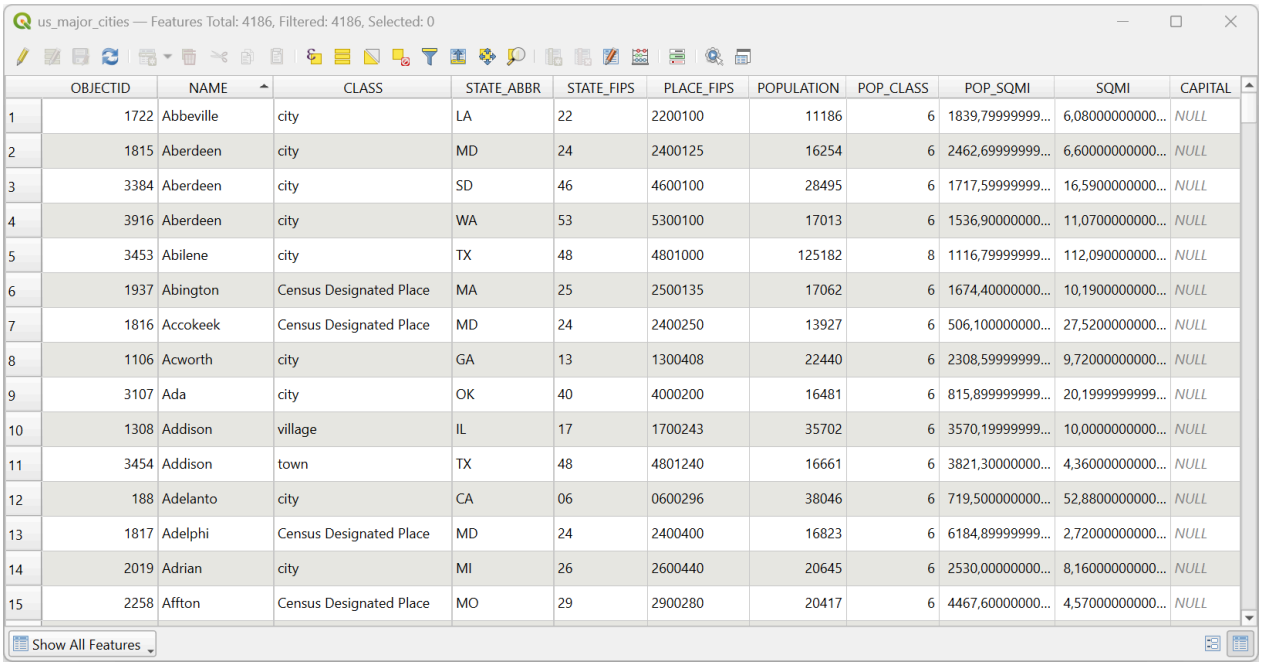
On the previous page all features of a layer got the same symbol (*Single Symbol*). Sometimes, however, you want to **differentiate visually between the features of one layer** based on a certain characteristic: for example, show the places in the United States in a different colour depending on their class (*city*, *town*, *village*...).

To do this, choose ***Categorized*** in the drop-down list at the top of the *Symbology* tab (A). With *Categorized*, every value of an attribute field gets its own symbol.




Under *Value* (H) you choose the attribute field on which you want to base the categories. The drop-down list shows all fields of the layer: the columns of its **attribute table**. The attribute table of the places

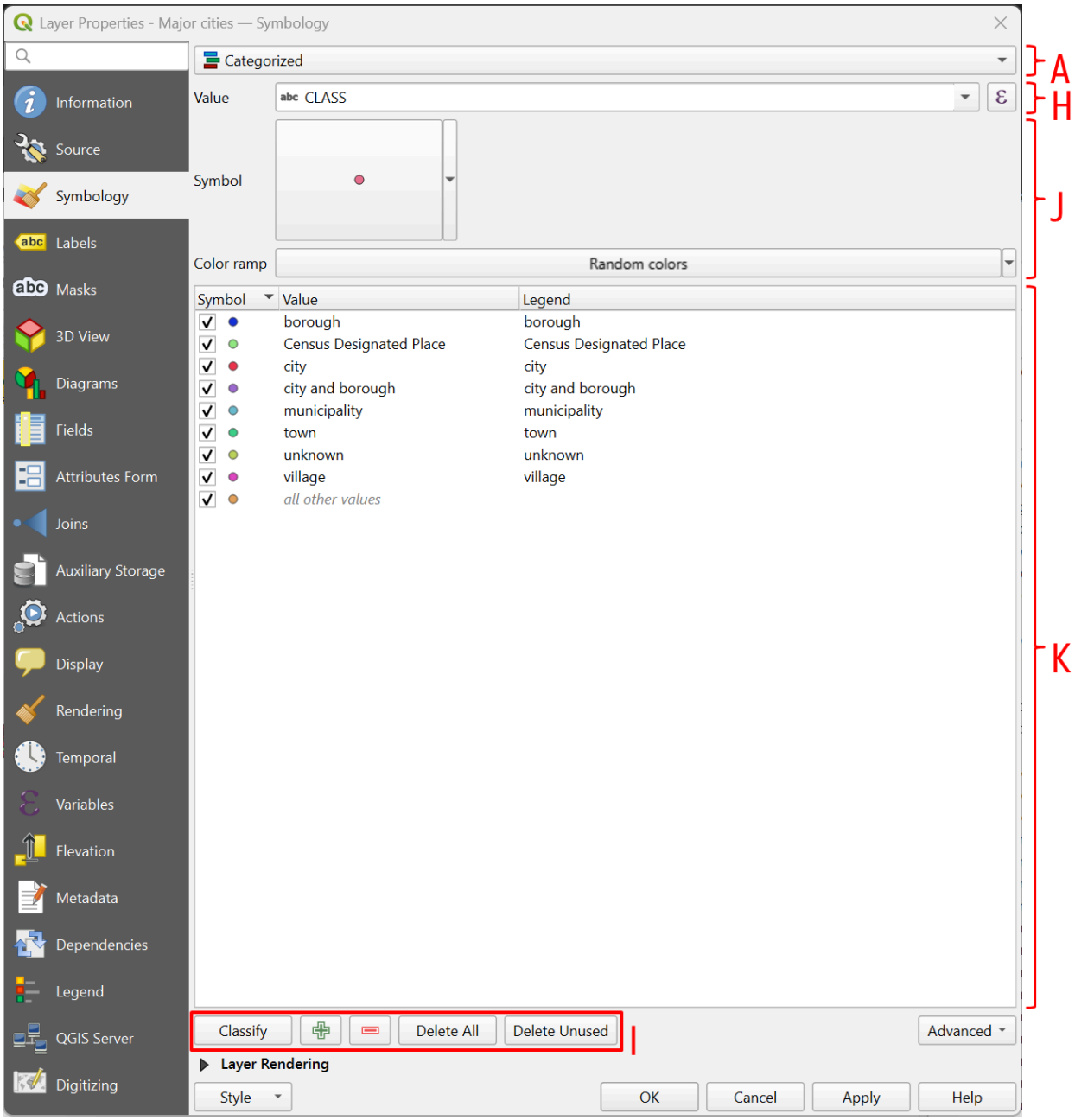
below, for example, contains for each place its name (`NAME`), its class (`CLASS`) and its number of inhabitants (`POPULATION`). In our example we categorise on `CLASS`.




| | OBJECTID | NAME | CLASS | STATE_ABBR | STATE_FIPS | PLACE_FIPS | POPULATION | POP_CLASS | POP_SQMI | SQMI | CAPITAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 1722 | Abbeville | city | LA | 22 | 2200100 | 11186 | 6 | 1839,79999999... | 6,08000000000... | NULL |
| 2 | 1815 | Aberdeen | city | MD | 24 | 2400125 | 16254 | 6 | 2462,69999999... | 6,60000000000... | NULL |
| 3 | 3384 | Aberdeen | city | SD | 46 | 4600100 | 28495 | 6 | 1717,59999999... | 16,5900000000... | NULL |
| 4 | 3916 | Aberdeen | city | WA | 53 | 5300100 | 17013 | 6 | 1536,90000000... | 11,0700000000... | NULL |
| 5 | 3453 | Abilene | city | TX | 48 | 4801000 | 125182 | 8 | 1116,79999999... | 112,090000000... | NULL |
| 6 | 1937 | Abington | Census Designated Place | MA | 25 | 2500135 | 17062 | 6 | 1674,40000000... | 10,1900000000... | NULL |
| 7 | 1816 | Accokeek | Census Designated Place | MD | 24 | 2400250 | 13927 | 6 | 506,100000000... | 27,5200000000... | NULL |
| 8 | 1106 | Acworth | city | GA | 13 | 1300408 | 22440 | 6 | 2308,59999999... | 9,72000000000... | NULL |
| 9 | 3107 | Ada | city | OK | 40 | 4000200 | 16481 | 6 | 815,899999999... | 20,1999999999... | NULL |
| 10 | 1308 | Addison | village | IL | 17 | 1700243 | 35702 | 6 | 3570,19999999... | 10,0000000000... | NULL |
| 11 | 3454 | Addison | town | TX | 48 | 4801240 | 16661 | 6 | 3821,30000000... | 4,36000000000... | NULL |
| 12 | 188 | Adelanto | city | CA | 06 | 0600296 | 38046 | 6 | 719,500000000... | 52,8800000000... | NULL |
| 13 | 1817 | Adelphi | Census Designated Place | MD | 24 | 2400400 | 16823 | 6 | 6184,89999999... | 2,72000000000... | NULL |
| 14 | 2019 | Adrian | city | MI | 26 | 2600440 | 20645 | 6 | 2530,00000000... | 8,16000000000... | NULL |
| 15 | 2258 | Affton | Census Designated Place | MO | 29 | 2900280 | 20417 | 6 | 4467,60000000... | 4,57000000000... | NULL |

Once you have selected the appropriate attribute field under *Value* (H), you can click *Classify* (I). QGIS then looks up all **unique values** of that field in the attribute table and lists them (K). Each value gets its own symbol, based on the symbol set under *Symbol* and with a colour from the selected *Color ramp* (J), by default random colours. At the bottom of the list QGIS also adds a category *all other values*, for features whose value does not appear in the list (for example values added to the data later).

After generating the categories, you can adjust each symbol individually: colour, shape, size… To do this, double-click the symbol you want to change under K. You can also edit the automatically created **descriptive legend**, which by default contains the name of the field value, by double-clicking the legend text. To delete a category from the list, select it and click the red minus button (I). To hide a category on the map without deleting it, untick the checkbox in front of it.




In some cases you do not want a separate category for every unique value, but only want to highlight a few values. Suppose, for example, that you want to highlight the places with the class `city` and show all other places in the same colour.

1. Choose the field `CLASS` under *Value* (H), as before. Do not click *Classify* this time, but click the green plus symbol (I). QGIS adds a new category to the list (K). Its value is still empty, so QGIS shows it as *all other values*.
2. Double-click the *Value* column of this category and type the value you want to highlight, in this case `city`.
3. Click the green plus symbol again to add a second category, and leave its value as it is (*all other values*). All features with another value, such as `town` or `village`, get the symbol of this category.
4. Give both categories the symbol you want.

Warning

**Values must match the attribute table exactly, including upper and lower case**: `city` is not the same as `City`.